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Shrek: the Unexpected Revenge Piece

In 1994, Walt Disney Company chairman Jeffery Katzenberg left the studio upon the conclusion of his contract. During his time at Disney, Katzenberg helped manage some of the company's most critically and financially successful movies, including *Beauty and the Beast* and *The Lion King*. Due to his growing success, Katzenberg believed that he should be promoted to president of the Disney company and that the current president, Frank Wells, should be demoted to vice chairman. However, even after Wells' death in 1994, Disney's then-CEO, Michael Eisner, refused to give Katzenberg the position, thus leading to Katzenberg departing from the company the same year. In the ultimate act of revenge, Katzenberg decided to form his own animation company called DreamWorks Animation, while also recruiting some of the top animators from Disney. It was through one of the studio's first films that DreamWorks Animation would solidify as a successful studio while also being a huge knock at Disney. In DreamWorks Animation's film *Shrek*, directors Andrew Adamson and Vicky Jenson use their character's traits and physical designs and the inclusion of modern pop songs as opposed to theatrical songs in order to mock the Disney company and establish a sense of justice for the mistreatment of the DreamWorks' CEO and animators.

Throughout *Shrek*'s runtime, Adamson and Jenson use the motives and physical designs of the characters within the movie in order to ridicule the Disney company. The way that Adamson and Jenson accomplish this goal is through the character of Lord Farquaad, who is

meant to be an unflattering parody of the then-Disney CEO, Michael Eisner. In *Shrek*, Lord Farquaad is the main villain of the movie who casts out the fairytale creatures from Duloc and tries to marry Princess Fiona in order to become king, and, therefore, become more powerful. Adamson and Jenson use Farquaad's hunger for power to symbolize Eisner and the direction he was taking the Disney company. At the time of *Shrek*'s development, Eisner was making moves to expand Disney and make it more lucrative and powerful. Under the reign of Eisner, the company acquired the ownership of many media sources and franchises such as ABC, ESPN, Fox Family, the Muppet franchise, and Pixar Animation Studios. These acquired properties would not only increase the amount of money that Disney made but also increase the power and influence they held as a company. Like Farquaad, despite being the ruler of one of the biggest kingdoms (or companies) in the world, Eisner continued to crave power and would stop at nothing to achieve corporate domination. Additionally, Adamson and Jenson use Lord Farquaad's character design to further mock Eisner. When comparing the "dictators," there are many physical similarities between Eisner and Farquaad. Both men have a sharp jawline, a protruding chin, and a pointy nose; and once one notices the resemblance between the two, it cannot go unnoticed. Through the character of Lord Farquaad, Adamson and Jenson successfully taunt the Disney company.

The music used throughout *Shrek* is another technique that Adamson and Jenson use to mock the Disney company. The two directors of the film achieve this goal through the usage of pop songs that play throughout the film. From as early as the opening scene, *Shrek* implements songs such as "All Star" and "I'm a Believer" as a way of expressing the tone of the scene or the feelings of the characters. This is distinctly different than Disney's usage of music in their movies, where they have original songs sung by the characters within their stories. Since *Shrek*

serves as a movie parody of fairytales, the goal of the creators is to diverge from the norm of fairytale stories. Since Disney films are so popular amongst general audiences, its adaptations of fairytale stories are the most popular interpretations. In Adamson and Jenson's goal to diverge from fairytale norms, they implement pop music into their story as opposed to the original theatrical songs normally featured in Disney movies. Additionally, the usage of pop music sticks out more to audiences. Since they have become overly exposed to original theatrical songs in Disney fairy tale movies, hearing the lyrics of "All Star" in the first few seconds of *Shrek* leaves more of an impact on them. Similar to the active usage of music, the idea of actively singing within the story, a trope that is extremely popular in Disney movies, is completely disregarded and belittled by the *Shrek* characters. Disney movies typically have their characters sing about their wants and desires, and the theatrical style of the songs always represents the magic and whimsy of their fairytale stories. This pattern of theatrical songs is so prevalent within Disney films that it has solidified itself as a part of their brand. However, whenever a character in *Shrek* tries to sing, the magic and whimsy are immediately shut down and mocked by the characters and the narrative. For example, when Shrek and Donkey first encounter one another after Donkey is freed from Lord Farquaad's guards, Donkey tries to sing a made-up song at which Shrek yells at him to stop. Later in the movie, when Fiona is wandering through a forest and tries to sing a beautiful melody, instead of attracting the forest animals much like a typical Disney princess, the melody violently explodes a bird. Through the *Shrek* narrative rejecting and ridiculing the idea of a character singing to express his or her feelings, the movie is rejecting the Disney company and everything it stands for. Adamson and Jenson are successful in their attempts to mock the Disney company through the usage of music in *Shrek*.

Throughout DreamWorks Animation's *Shrek*, Adamson and Jenson use their characters' traits and physical designs and implement modern pop songs instead of theatrical songs in order to ridicule the Disney company and establish a sense of justice for the mistreatment of DreamWorks' CEO and animators. The character of Lord Farquaad being a distasteful parody of then-Disney CEO Michael Eisner helped to expose the selfish business practices that Eisner was taking with the Disney company. Additionally, the usage of pop songs and disapproval of characters singing within the story actively rejects the norm that Disney has successfully set up in the past with their fairytale movies. Regardless of the impact that the *Shrek* film itself had on the Disney company, it was the success that followed that would impact Disney. *Shrek* would be a critical and financial success, and the trends within the movie would begin to show up in other children's animated movies. From its 3-D model of animation, crude and sometimes adult-level humor, and cast of A-list celebrities, film studios began to take notes and try to replicate the success of *Shrek* within their movies. Soon, it seemed that movies like *Shrek* began to be the social norm of children's entertainment, and it would not be long before Disney started releasing films mimicking *Shrek*'s successful attributes.